Bhindranwale had escaped just before or during Operation Blue Star. Going by the contents of the placard mentioned above, several Sikhs also believed that Amrik Singh and Thara Singh (and by implication, Bhindranwale) were captured alive and thereafter tortured to death.

The next morning, I called on Director (R) Gary Saxena in his office and informed him of what I had seen and observed in Gurudwara Bangla Sahib complex, especially the contents of the placard. I told him that going even by elementary knowledge of Sikh history, there would be a large number of Sikhs, specially from the rural areas, willing to risk their lives to avenge the damage caused to the Harmandir Sahib complex. Their target would be Indira Gandhi.

Coming straight to the point, I said that in my assessment there was a high probability of her being assassinated in the next six months, and it was the duty of the concerned security agencies to save her life at all costs. Gary asked me how, when and where such an attempt would be made. Based on my experience of working in Uttar Pradesh Police, where I had supervised some election rallies addressed by Indira Gandhi, I said that soon after her speech at an election rally, she would normally go towards the ladies' enclosure located on the left side of the rostrum, where she would meet and speak with women and receive garlands from them. In the haste and confusion that followed, she would be exposed to elements that were beyond the limits prescribed by her security set-up, thereby becoming an easy target. Tragically, it would be at an election rally that her son Rajiv Gandhi would be assassinated in a somewhat similar manner by a seventeen-year-old LTTE suicide bomber on 21 May 1991 at Sriperumbudur in Tamil Nadu.

Having heard my assessment, Gary remarked that if such a thing happened there would be large-scale killing of Sikhs in Delhi. It appeared the subject had been discussed the previous day at a high-level meeting, either at the cabinet secretariat or the PMO, where the likelihood of Indira Gandhi's assassination and its repercussions were also discussed. 'That is what they want,' I said. When Gary asked who 'they' were, I said, 'Obviously, Pakistan, and some